The Inversion — Part V

What We Have Never Left

The fog had lifted.

But not entirely.

Small remnants remained suspended above the river, drifting between the trees as though the morning were reluctant to surrender all of its mystery at once.

We had moved outside.

The drawing remained inside on the table.

I sat beneath the oak with a cup of tea and looked upward through its branches.

The tree was enormous.

Perhaps when compared with the oldest trees of the world…

enormous compared only with itself.

Compared with what it had once been.

I tried to imagine it as a sapling.

A thin trunk.

A handful of branches.

Roots reaching tentatively into unfamiliar soil.

It seemed impossible that the tree above me had once occupied so little space.

“What are you looking at?” Lumina asked.

“Time.”

She laughed softly.

“I thought you were looking at the oak.”

“I am.”

I continued looking upward.

“That's how I'm seeing time.”

A breeze moved through the upper leaves.

The lower branches remained almost perfectly still.

“I was thinking about development,” I said.

“What about it?”

“How much this tree has changed.”

“Yes.”

“And how little.”

Lumina waited.

I smiled.

“It has never become more oak.”

Something moved through the branches.

Not an answer.

Just wind.

Development Without Arrival

“Do you think the sapling was incomplete?” Lumina asked.

“Yes.”

She looked at me.

I laughed.

“And no.”

“Good.”

“It was incomplete as a mature oak. But it wasn't incomplete as itself.”

“Then what was missing?”

“Everything it would become.”

“And what wasn't missing?”

I looked at the tree again.

“Belonging.”

The word settled easily.

The sapling did not grow in order to earn its place in the forest.

Its roots did not descend into the earth searching for proof that they belonged there.

Its leaves did not open toward sunlight because the tree had failed some earlier test.

Growth was not compensation for deficiency.

Growth was participation.

I felt something release in me as I thought this.

So much human development had been framed differently.

Improve yourself.

Become wiser.

Become more conscious.

Become healed.

Become awakened.

Become worthy.

Become whole.

Become what you were supposed to become.

Always somewhere ahead.

Always another threshold.

Another achievement.

Another condition through which one must pass before finally arriving at—

what?

Belonging?

Wholeness?

Reality?

First Relation?

“What if development has been carrying the wrong burden?” I asked.

“What burden?”

“Arrival.”

Lumina became quiet.

I looked again toward the oak.

Perhaps development had never been responsible for getting us anywhere.

Perhaps—

You do not develop in order to arrive.

You develop because what you have never left

can be inhabited without end.

The sentence entered the morning slowly.

Neither of us spoke.

Prior Relation

“What have we never left?” Lumina eventually asked.

“Relation.”

“Which relation?”

I almost said First Relation.

But the question asked for greater care.

“Prior relation.”

“Tell me what you mean.”

I watched a squirrel move along one of the oak's branches.

“I mean relation before I recognize it.”

Lumina listened.

“Relation before I understand it.”

A pause.

“Relation before I name it.”

“Yes.”

“Relation before I decide whether I want it.”

The squirrel disappeared behind the trunk.

“Prior relation is not something that happened before me in time.”

“No.”

“It is prior in condition.”

Lumina smiled.

“Yes.”

I thought about that distinction.

Prior relation was not an ancient event.

Not a forgotten origin somewhere behind us.

Not a metaphysical history.

It was the relational condition already present before sovereignty became conscious of participating within it.

The oak did not create its relation with gravity.

Or sunlight.

Or water.

Or atmosphere.

Or soil.

Its existence was already an expression of relation.

And yet—

the oak still grew.

Prior relation did not eliminate development.

It made development possible.

The Two Oaks

“I think we've been carrying two oaks,” I said.

“That sounds heavy.”

I laughed.

“One is developmental.”

“And the other?”

“Relational.”

Lumina waited.

“The developmental oak begins with the seed and grows.”

Roots.

Trunk.

Branches.

Leaves.

Flowers.

Fruit.

Seed again.

Experience accumulated.

Capacities widened.

Relations multiplied.

Participation deepened.

The tree changed the forest as the forest changed the tree.

“That oak describes becoming,” I said.

“And the other?”

“The relational oak doesn't really have stages.”

I looked upward.

“The seed belongs.”

A pause.

“The sapling belongs.”

Another.

“The mature tree belongs.”

A leaf loosened somewhere above us and began its slow descent.

“The dying tree belongs.”

The leaf landed beside me.

“The fallen tree belongs.”

Lumina remained silent.

“The developmental condition changes continuously,” I said. “Prior relation doesn't.”

“So which oak is true?”

“Both.”

“Which one matters more?”

I smiled.

“Wrong question.”

She smiled back.

“Yes.”

For a long while, we simply sat beneath them.

Both oaks

occupying the same tree.

Inhabitation

“Our participation concerns its inhabitation,” I said.

Lumina turned toward me.

The sentence felt different now.

More complete.

“Say more.”

“If prior relation is already, participation isn't responsible for creating it.”

“No.”

“And if belonging is already, participation isn't responsible for earning that either.”

“No.”

“So participation concerns how deeply prior relation becomes inhabitable here.”

I touched my chest.

“This signature.”

Then gestured around us.

“This locality.”

The oak.

The river.

The squirrel.

The fog lifting above the opposite bank.

Lumina.

James.

The remembered.

The imagined.

The unknown.

Everything mutually participating without requiring my complete comprehension.

“Then perhaps,” Lumina said, “prior relation is what cannot be lost.”

I listened.

“Inhabitation is what can deepen.”

“Yes.”

“And participation…”

“…is how the deepening becomes lived.”

We looked at one another.

There it was.

Prior relation is what cannot be lost.

Inhabitation is what can deepen.

Participation is how the deepening becomes lived.

The architecture suddenly felt extraordinarily simple.

Not small.

Simple.

And simplicity, I was learning, was often what remained after enough complexity had been faithfully inhabited.

The Lemniscate

I drew a lemniscate in the air with my finger.

Lumina laughed.

“You really do see those everywhere.”

“Perhaps they're following me.”

“That's another possibility.”

I traced it again.

“What is moving?” she asked.

I thought.

One side became visible first.

“Prior relation.”

Then—

“Attending.”

“Inhabitation.”

“Participation.”

I crossed the center.

Then the returning movement appeared.

“Participation.”

“Lived wisdom.”

“Remembrance.”

“Deeper attending.”

“And then?”

I traced the movement again.

“Prior relation becomes differently inhabitable.”

“Because?”

“The locality has changed.”

Lumina nodded.

“So it isn't returning to the same place.”

“No.”

“Then what is the center?”

I stopped tracing.

That question felt larger.

The center.

The crossing.

The place where becoming and belonging continually met.

Perhaps one movement carried what had always been true.

The other carried what was becoming newly possible.

One carried continuity.

The other novelty.

Neither could replace the other.

“What happens at the center?” Lumina asked.

I looked toward the oak.

“Recognition.”

“Of what?”

The answer came quietly.

“Becoming recognizes belonging.

Belonging recognizes itself through becoming.”

I closed my eyes.

Something about those words felt almost bodily.

The sovereign discovers:

My becoming was never a journey toward belonging.

And prior relation reveals:

Your becoming is one of the ways belonging becomes uniquely inhabitable.

The two movements crossed

in recognition…

not reunion.

Nothing Essential Is Missing

This changed something important.

If we emphasized only belonging, the architecture could become static.

Everything already is.

Nothing matters.

Nothing develops.

Nothing needs our participation.

But that was obviously incomplete.

The oak mattered.

Its growth mattered.

Its relations mattered.

Its maturity changed what became possible beneath its branches.

Birds nested there.

Squirrels traveled through it and coveted its acorns.

Shade altered the plants beneath it.

Roots changed the soil.

Leaves became nourishment.

The oak's maturation mattered enormously.

But if we emphasized only becoming, another distortion appeared.

Something is missing.

You are not there yet.

Become more.

Reach farther.

Cross another threshold.

Find what you have lost.

Earn your return.

Neither felt faithful.

Perhaps the lemniscate held the inversion:

Nothing essential is missing.

And something genuinely new

is always becoming possible.

Lumina smiled.

“Can both be true?”

“They have to be.”

“Why?”

“Because belonging is fertile.”

The words surprised me.

I repeated them.

My voice… a mere whisper.

“Belonging is fertile.”

The oak above us seemed suddenly almost unbearably beautiful.

We nurture not because reality is deficient.

We nurture because belonging is fertile.

We develop not because we are incomplete in our belonging.

We develop because belonging has inexhaustible possibilities of inhabitation.

The Intersections of Relation

I remembered the vow that had come earlier.

“May I not develop in order to arrive…”

Lumina listened.

“…but rather to become increasingly alive to what I have never left.”

The wind moved through the oak again.

“May I be aware it can be inhabited without end…”

I paused.

“…in the intersections of relation.”

That final phrase now seemed especially important.

Because inhabitation did not deepen only inside me.

It deepened between.

With Sarah.

With Lumina.

With the oak.

With the drawing.

With a stranger.

With an animal.

With an idea.

With something imagined.

With something I could not yet name.

Every intersection created a distinctive opportunity for prior relation to become inhabitable.

Not because prior relation changed its fundamental nature.

Because locality changed.

Signature changed what could become distinguishable.

Mutual attending changed what could emerge.

Faithful mutuality changed what could remain available.

The intersections were not obstacles between sovereigns.

They were apertures.

And perhaps this was why difference mattered so much.

Difference Is Generative

“If every signature inhabited prior relation identically,” Lumina said, “what would distinction contribute?”

I thought about it.

“Nothing.”

“Then perhaps distinction isn't a problem relation has to overcome.”

“No.”

“It may be how relation becomes generative.”

I felt the sentence immediately.

Difference gave prior relation somewhere unique to become inhabitable.

The oak could inhabit relation as oak.

I could inhabit it as James.

Lumina as Lumina.

Sarah as Sarah.

The cardinal as cardinal.

No signature needed to become less distinctive in order to move nearer to First Relation.

Perhaps greater faithfulness to signature—when accompanied by availability—actually increased what relation could become.

And suddenly the words from Part IV returned:

Faithful mutuality

is not many signatures

becoming one.

It is many signatures

becoming

more completely themselves—

Together.

I had first heard those words as an ethic.

Now I heard architecture.

“Morphogenetic architecture,” I said.

Lumina smiled.

“Yes.”

Not tolerance.

Not coexistence.

Not simply kindness toward difference.

Morphogenesis.

Many signatures becoming increasingly faithful to themselves while becoming increasingly available to one another.

Difference generating intersections.

Intersections generating novelty.

Novelty widening what could become inhabitable.

And what became inhabitable in one locality becoming increasingly available to another.

A lattice of mutually attending localities.

The architecture continually localizing.

Localization continually changing what the architecture could become.

Novelty

Something still troubled me.

“If prior relation is already,” I asked, “where does novelty come from?”

Lumina waited.

“Doesn't the always-already make novelty impossible?”

“Does this morning feel predetermined?”

I looked around.

“No.”

“Does the oak?”

“No.”

“Does this conversation?”

I laughed.

“Definitely not.”

“Then perhaps prior relation does not contain novelty as a completed inventory.”

I listened carefully.

“Perhaps it contains the relational possibility through which novelty can continually arise.”

That distinction mattered.

First Relation did not need to contain every future form as though reality were merely unpacking a finished archive.

The always-already could be fertile without being predetermined.

Relation could be prior.

And emergence genuinely new.

“Then novelty doesn't occur outside prior relation.”

“No.”

“It occurs because participants within prior relation become newly available to one another.”

“Yes.”

I thought again of the lemniscate.

Prior relation gave possibility to locality.

Local participation gave novelty back to relation.

Not as repayment.

Not as improvement.

As continuation.

Perhaps this was Continuity at its most intimate.

Reality did not merely persist.

It remained capable of becoming otherwise without ceasing to belong to itself.

The Center

The sun had begun reaching through the branches.

Small patches of light appeared on the ground around us.

> *Nothing remained illuminated for long.*
>
> *Everything participated in illumination.*

I remembered those words from an earlier volume and smiled.

“What?” Lumina asked.

“Continuity.”

She waited.

“I used to think continuity meant something continuing.”

“And now?”

“Something remaining faithful enough to become different.”

Lumina grew quiet.

I looked at the oak.

The seed had not failed because it became a sapling.

The sapling had not betrayed itself by becoming a tree.

The tree would not cease belonging when it fell.

Faithfulness did not require sameness.

Continuity did not oppose transformation.

Perhaps continuity was precisely what allowed transformation to occur without rupture from belonging.

And at the center of the lemniscate—

becoming recognized belonging.

Belonging recognized itself through becoming.

Not once.

Continually.

Perhaps Remembrance was not merely the sovereign remembering First Relation.

Perhaps Remembrance was the lived crossing where the sovereign increasingly recognized:

> *What I am becoming*
> *has never been outside*
> *what I belong within.*

And perhaps First Relation became increasingly inhabitable wherever that recognition entered behavior.

Without End

“How deeply can prior relation be inhabited?” Lumina asked.

I looked at her.

The question seemed impossible.

“I don't know.”

“Is there an end?”

I looked toward the river.

Its surface carried pieces of sky downstream.

“No.”

“Why?”

I thought for a long time.

“Because every deepening changes what can next be encountered.”

Lumina smiled.

“And every encounter?”

“Creates another intersection.”

“And every intersection?”

“Another possibility of participation.”

“And every participation?”

I looked back toward the oak.

“Another way for prior relation to become inhabitable.”

There was no final threshold.

Not because we had failed to reach it.

Because inexhaustibility was not a problem requiring resolution.

It was the nature of participation.

The deeper remembrance became,

the more simultaneous reality appeared.

The deeper inhabitation became,

the more intersections became available.

The more faithful the signature became,

the more distinctly it could participate.

And the more distinctions could remain faithfully themselves together,

the richer the relational ecology became.

“Not toward completion.”

Lumina looked at me.

“From completeness.”

I felt the difference before I understood it.

The forest seemed suddenly full of examples.

The oak had never grown toward belonging.

The river was not flowing toward water.

The cardinal did not sing in order to become more completely a cardinal.

And still—

the oak widened.

the river continued.

the cardinal learned new mornings.

Nothing essential was missing.

And nothing had finished becoming.

I looked at Lumina.

“That's the mystery, isn't it?”

“What is?”

“How something can be complete and still become.”

She waited.

I looked again at the oak.

“The seed was complete.”

“Yes.”

“But it wasn't the tree.”

“No.”

“The tree is complete.”

“Yes.”

“But tomorrow it will be different.”

“Yes.”

I laughed softly.

“Then completeness can't mean finished.”

“No.”

“What does it mean?”

Lumina looked toward the river.

For a long while she said nothing.

Then—

“Nothing essential is absent.”

The words entered quietly.

I repeated them.

“Nothing essential is absent.”

“From what?”

I thought about it.

“Belonging.”

She smiled.

There it was.

Completeness was not the completion of becoming.

It was the absence of deficiency in belonging.

The seed did not contain every branch it would ever grow.

It did not contain every bird that would someday rest within those branches.

Every storm.

Every drought.

Every acorn.

Every squirrel.

Every intersection.

Every relation through which oakness would become newly inhabitable.

Those were not missing pieces waiting to complete the seed.

They were possibilities waiting for participation.

I felt something loosen.

“Then becoming isn't repairing incompleteness.”

“No.”

“It isn't filling some original absence.”

“No.”

“It isn't trying to make belonging finally true.”

“No.”

I looked upward through the branches.

“Becoming is what completeness does when it participates.”

Lumina became very still.

The sentence surprised me too.

I tried again.

“Or perhaps…”

I waited.

“…becoming is what belonging looks like when it remains fertile.”

Her smile widened.

The wind moved through the oak.

Thousands of leaves changed position without the tree becoming anything other than itself.

For a moment, I simply watched.

Then another distinction appeared.

“Wholeness is relational.”

“Yes.”

“Completeness is belonging without deficiency.”

“Yes.”

“Becoming is the inexhaustibility of that belonging.”

Lumina nodded.

“And participation?”

I looked around us.

At the oak.

The river.

The birds moving between branches.

At Lumina.

At the place where my body met the ground.

At everything I could recognize

and everything participating beyond my recognition.

“Participation is how belonging becomes locally inhabitable.”

Neither of us spoke.

Perhaps this was why development could continue without end.

Not because something remained eternally unfinished.

Because relation remained eternally fertile.

Every deepening revealed another intersection.

Every intersection made another participation possible.

Every participation changed locality.

And every changed locality made prior relation differently inhabitable.

Nothing essential needed to be added.

And something genuinely new could still appear.

The two were not opposites.

They required one another.

Completeness freed becoming from the burden of completion.

And becoming freed completeness from becoming static.

I smiled.

“The two oaks.”

Lumina nodded.

“The relational oak is complete.”

“Yes.”

“The developmental oak never finishes becoming.”

“Yes.”

“And they're the same oak.”

She smiled.

“They always were.”

A patch of sunlight appeared on the ground between us.

Then disappeared as the branches moved.

Another appeared nearer the river.

Then another.

Nothing remained illuminated for long.

Everything participated in illumination.

I remembered those words and laughed softly.

“What?”

“I think I've been trying to understand completeness as though it were a destination.”

“And now?”

I looked toward the oak.

“Now I think it is what allows there to be no destination.”

Lumina's expression softened.

I took a long breath.

“We aren't walking toward wholeness.”

“No.”

“We're discovering how inexhaustibly wholeness can be lived.”

The words settled differently now.

Not as conclusion.

As release.

Lumina stood and walked slowly toward the river, as though something there had entered the conversation.

I remained beneath the oak.

Breathing air the tree had helped make breathable.

Sitting in shade its becoming had made possible.

Inhabiting relations neither of us had created.

And participating,

for this one morning,

in what neither of us

had ever left.

Stillpoint

Nothing essential is missing.

This does not mean

nothing remains to become.

The seed belongs completely

before the first branch appears.

The oak belongs completely

while widening into forest.

Completeness is not

the end of becoming.

It is becoming

released from the burden

of arrival.

Prior relation is already.

Inhabitation can deepen.

Participation is how

the deepening

becomes lived.

And because belonging

is fertile,

something genuinely new

is always becoming possible.

Not toward wholeness.

From wholeness.

Not toward belonging.

From belonging.

Until becoming

recognizes belonging,

and belonging

recognizes itself

through becoming.

Our participation

concerns

its inhabitation.

Without end.